MODULE 6: Cheap Fakes

Objective
To help participants understand:
- What cheap fakes are.
- Why they spread more widely than deepfakes.
- How simple editing techniques can produce misleading content.
- How to identify and respond to cheap fakes as informed citizens.

6.1 What Is a Cheap Fake?
A cheap fake is misleading image, video, or audio content created without advanced technology or artificial intelligence.
Such content is produced through simple editing, cutting, changes in playback speed, or the addition of misleading text.
The defining characteristic of cheap fakes is that they are easy and inexpensive to create, yet can have a significant impact.

Examples:
- Using basic photo editing to place one person's face onto another person's body.
- Cutting and rearranging an audio recording to make someone appear to say something they never said.
- Using misleading edits or captions to present an event or statement inaccurately.

6.2 Why Are Cheap Fakes Dangerous?
Many people assume that cheap fakes are relatively harmless because they do not involve advanced technology. In reality, they can:
- Go viral very quickly.
- Be readily accepted as genuine.
- Escape verification because people assume their authenticity is easy to judge.
- Misrepresent real events or individuals.

Cheap fakes can often trigger widespread confusion.

6.3 Common Forms of Cheap Fakes
Cheap fakes commonly take the following forms:

1. Changes in Video Speed
Slowing down or speeding up a video to create a different impression.

2. Image Cropping
Showing only a selected part of an image to create a misleading impression.

3. Incorrect Captions or Descriptions
Adding false information to an authentic image or video.

4. Audio Splicing
Cutting and joining portions of speech to create a statement with a different meaning.

5. Misleading Screenshots or Thumbnails
Using a single frame to misrepresent the meaning of an entire video.

6.4 How Cheap Fakes Spread
Common channels through which cheap fakes spread include:
- Sharing on social media.
- Facebook groups and pages.
- Forwards through WhatsApp or Messenger.
- Posts accompanied by emotionally charged captions.

Cheap fakes are often designed to prompt people to share them before pausing to think.

6.5 Why People Believe Cheap Fakes

Several psychological factors contribute to people's acceptance of cheap fakes:

- Images and videos appear credible because people can "see them with their own eyes."
- Familiar faces or places make people less likely to question the content.
- Strong emotions can weaken critical judgement.
- People may assume, "If so many people are sharing it, how could it be wrong?"

As a result, cheap fakes can quickly gain credibility.

6.6 Warning Signs of Cheap Fakes

Look out for the following warning signs:

- Video playback that is unusually slow or fast.
- A mismatch between the caption and the visual content.
- Unclear timing or context.
- A missing or unclear source.
- Only part of a video or image being shown.

When in doubt, seek out the complete, original content to assess its context.

6.7 Cheap Fakes vs. Deepfakes

Aspect	Cheap Fakes	Deepfakes
Technology	Basic editing	AI or Advanced technology
Creation	Easy	Complex
Detection	Relatively easy	Difficult
Spread	Very rapid	Slower with a profound impact

6.8 Cheap Fakes in the Bangladesh Context

Cheap fakes pose particular risks in Bangladesh because:

- Much of the content is created and consumed on mobile devices.
- Short videos spread rapidly.
- A culture of verifying information remains limited.
- Social and political issues often evoke strong emotions.

Cheap fakes can cause widespread confusion, particularly when they concern elections, social events, or public figures.

6.9 What to Do When You Encounter a Cheap Fake

DO:

- Pause before sharing.
- Find the complete video or the original source of the image.

Don't:

- Share emotionally.
- Comment without checking.
- Trust video alone.